

## Response Letter with Annotations

Barari, S. (2024). Political Speech from Corporate America: Sparse, Mostly for Democrats, and Somewhat Representative. *Journal of Quantitative Description: Digital Media*, 4. <https://doi.org/10.51685/jqd.2024.icwsm.5>

### Annotations

#### 1. Purposes

- a. **Motivation (one sentence summary)** – How do corporations engage in political speech on social media? What are attributes of their partisan signals?
- b. **Specific Rationale (several bullet points)**
  - i. No comprehensive study exists describing corporate political communication
  - ii. Corporations spend significantly more on advertising/PR than on federal lobbying
  - iii. Social media has become a powerful platform for corporations to set political agendas
- c. **Research Questions**
  - i. **RQ1:** To what extent do major U.S. corporations send political signals in mass public communications?
  - ii. **RQ2:** Where do these signals fall on the partisan spectrum?
  - iii. **RQ3:** Is this speech representative of stakeholder preferences and informative about firm activities/priorities?
  - iv. **Independent Variable:**
    1. Stakeholder preferences
    2. Firm agendas
  - v. **Dependent Variable:** Partisan brand signals
  - vi. **Mediators:** None identified, further study needed
  - vii. **Moderators:** None identified, further study needed
  - viii. **Specific relationships among variables** – examining alignment between brand signals and stakeholder political preferences/firm activities in related political areas.

#### 2. Methods

- a. **Research Design**
  - i. Descriptive correlational study
  - ii. Text-as-data analysis
  - iii. Cross-sectional analysis with time-series components
- b. **Sample (representative sample?)**
  - i. Population: 1186 most recognized consumer brands in the US (from YouGov Audience panel)
  - ii. Final Sample: 879 brands with active Twitter and/or Instagram accounts

- iii. Representative: Sample represents highly visible consumer-facing brands

**c. Measures/Analysis**

**i. Partisan Brand Signal Measurement**

1. Collected ~2 million social media posts from brands (2015-2021)
2. Reference corpus: ~1.4 million posts from members of the 116th Congress
3. Identified 1000 most partisan bigrams using  $\chi^2$  statistic
4. Non-parametric weighted count measure of partisan lean
5. Parametric models and platform-specific models included as well

**ii. Stakeholder Preference Measures**

1. FEC campaign donations
2. Twitter follower partisan composition
3. Presidential vote share in headquarters/retail location zip codes
4. DW-NOMINATE scores for representative of HQ locations

**iii. Firm Agenda Measures**

1. PAC spending
2. Climate policy indicators
3. DEI measures
4. Regulatory violations

**iv. Analysis**

1. Pearson correlations
2. Univariate regressions
3. Benjamini-Hochberg adjustments for multiple testing
4. Equivalence tests for effect sizes
5. Robustness checks

**3. Results and Conclusions**

**a. Answers to RQs and Hypotheses**

**i. RQ1:**

1. 64% of brands use any partisan bigrams during the study period
2. 33% use more than 15 partisan bigrams
3. Most brands sparingly send partisan signals

**ii. RQ2:**

1. 73% of partisan cues lean left/Democrat
2. Most common cue types: political issues (27%); sociopolitical groups (22%); political expressions (20%)
3. Top Democrat phases: “climate change,” “gun violence,” “health care”
4. Lean is moderate

**iii. RQ3:**

**1. Stakeholder alignment:** Moderate positive correlations between brand signals and stakeholder preferences

**2. Firm Agenda Alignment:** Weak to moderate correlations

**b. Author's Conclusions**

- i. Other temporal patterns:
  - 1. Sharp increase in Democrat-leaning speech after George Floyd murder (May 2020)
  - 2. Minimal response to January 6th Capitol insurrection
  - 3. Pre-2020, partisan cues were more balanced
- ii. Most brands are not meaningfully political in their speech
- iii. Those that are political lean democrat
- iv. Speech is “not as dishonest as popular narratives suggest” (p. 1)
- v. Partisan speech representative stakeholder preferences well, and is “somewhat informative” about firm priorities (p.1)

**4. Discussion**

**a. Implications**

**i. Theoretical:**

- 1. Supports stakeholder theory: brands consider multiple stakeholder preferences
- 2. Diploma divide: educated, diverse workforces predict liberal signals
- 3. Activating elements shift corporate agenda progressively (i.e. George Floyd)
- 4. Tech and retail show strongest stakeholder alignment

**ii. Practical:**

- 1. Large brands that are more popular with Democrat stakeholders produce more partisan cues overall
- 2. Liberal bubble

**b. Limitations**

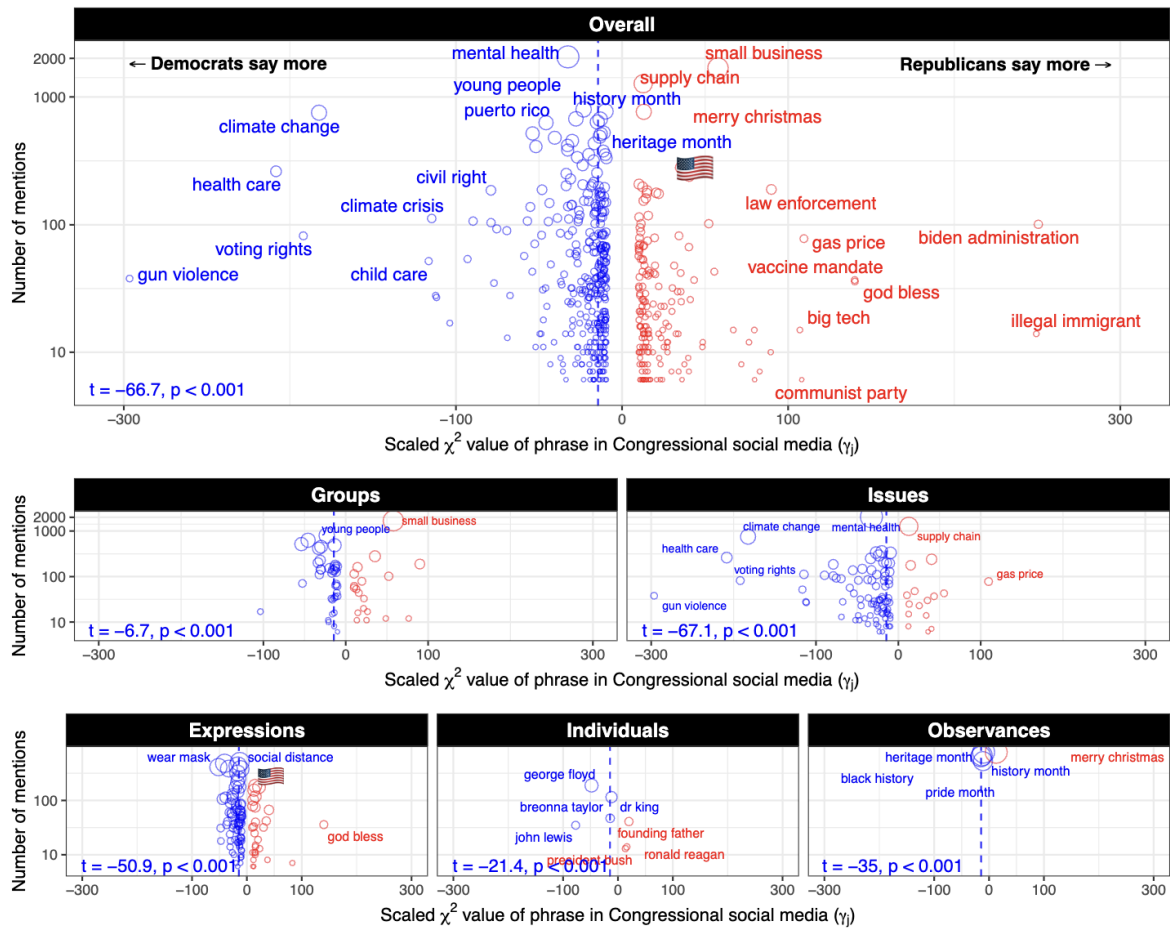
- i. Descriptive/correlational design (not causal)
- ii. Cannot determine direction (brands responding to stakeholders v. stakeholder responding to brands)
- iii. Voluntary firm disclosures for ratings → Selection bias?
- iv. Focus on highly visible brands → generalizability?
- v. Limited to Twitter/Instagram
- vi. Small effect sizes for many relationships indicated

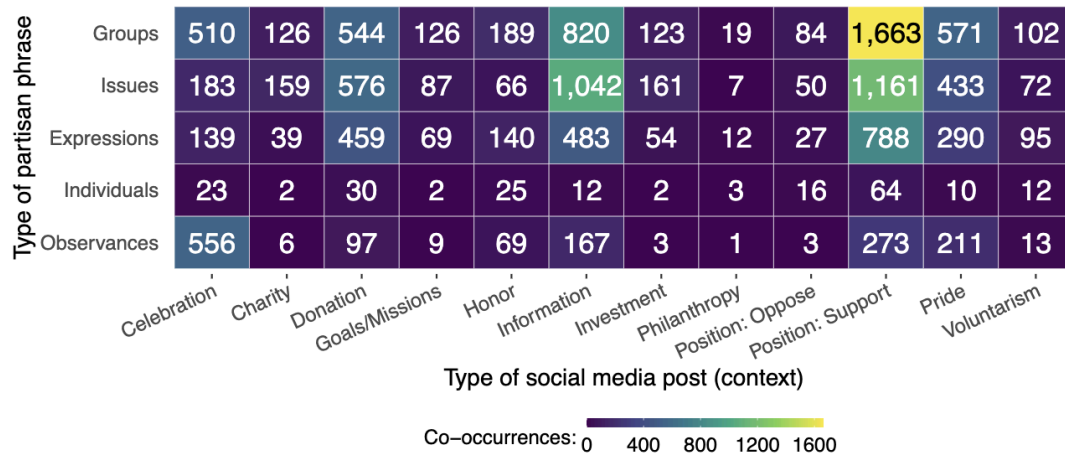
**c. Future Directions**

- i. Clarify causal direction of brand-stakeholder alignment
- ii. Uncover mechanisms behind political signaling decisions
- iii. Study other stakeholders

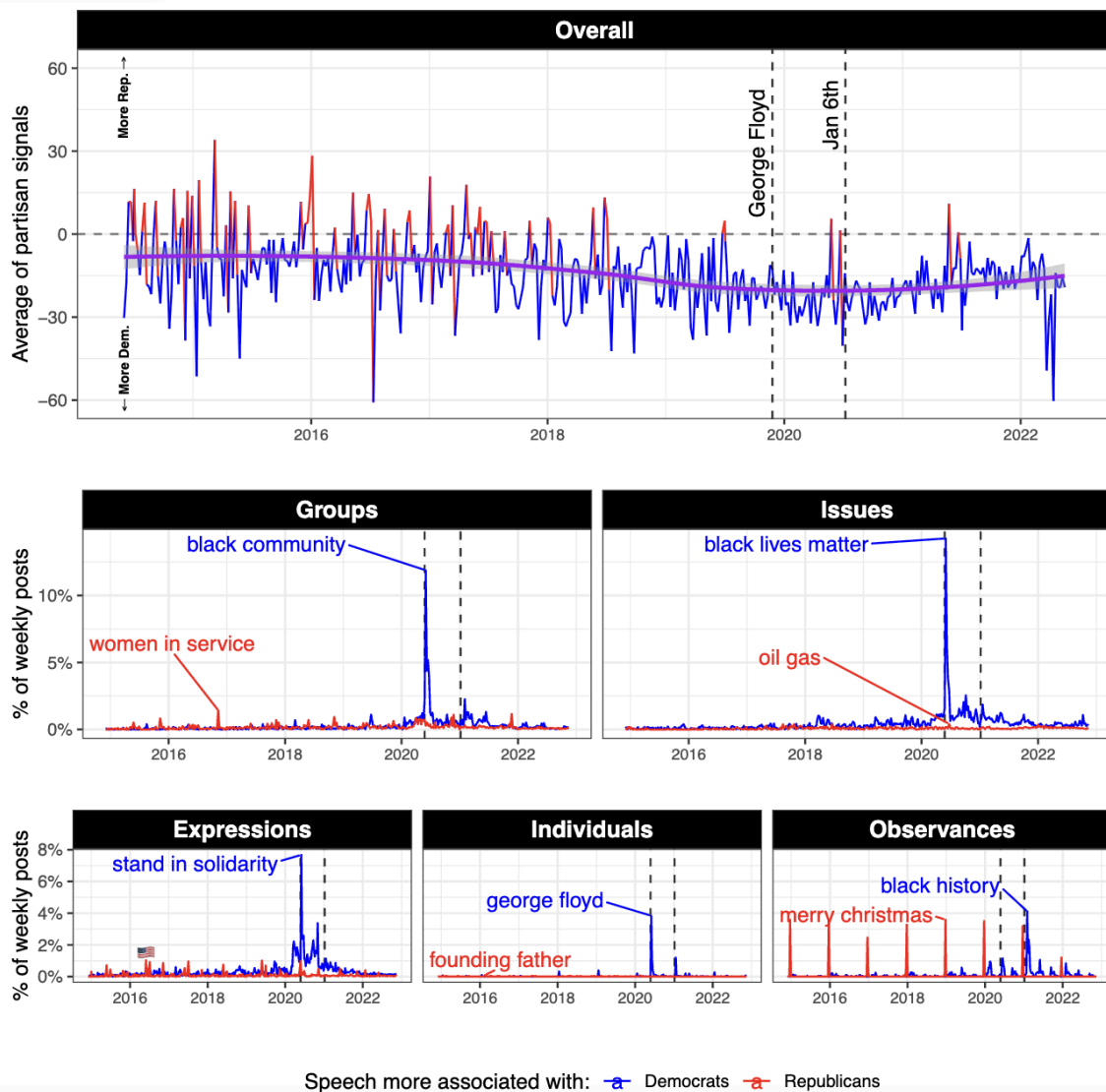
- iv. Expand to other platforms
- v. Post-2021 trends
- vi. Alternative measurement strategies
- vii. Mediators and moderators, other activating events

## Key Figures/Tables





**Figure 3. Contexts for Partisan Brand Signals**



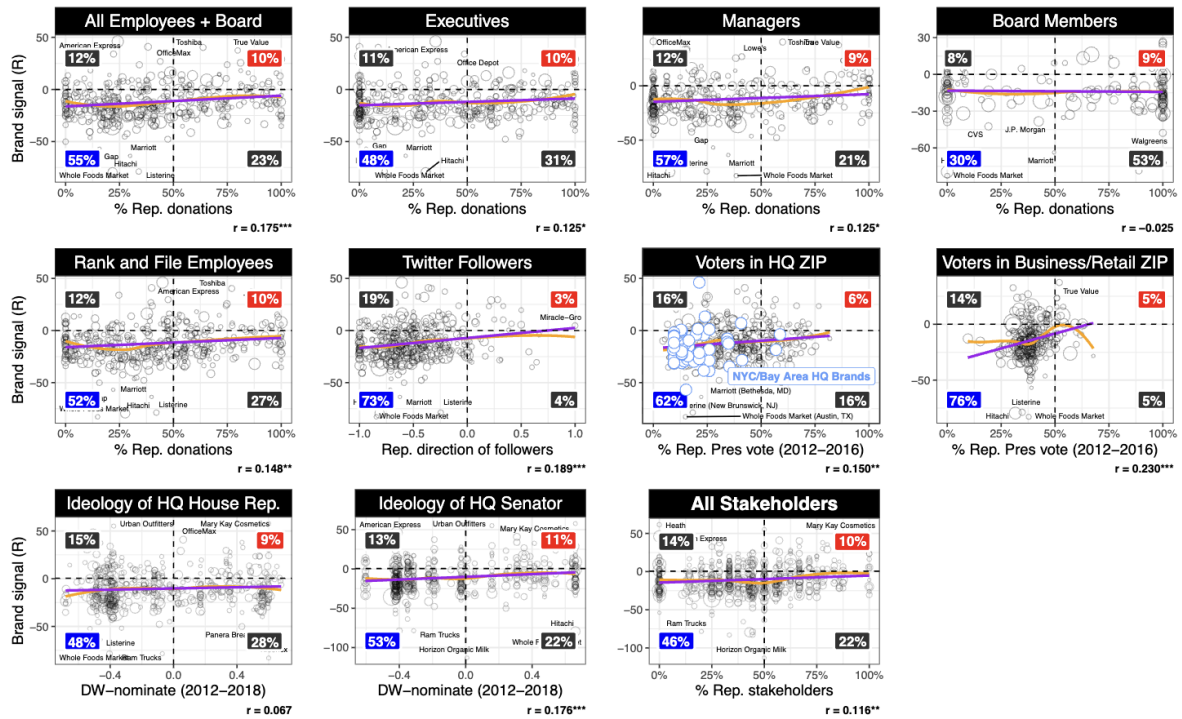


Figure 5. Alignment Between Brand Signals and Partisan Stakeholder Preferences

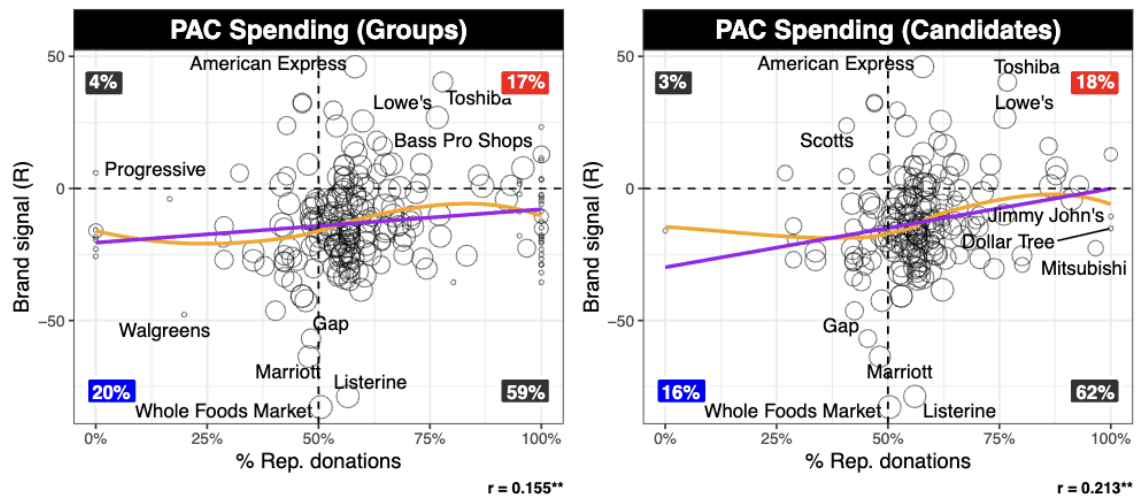
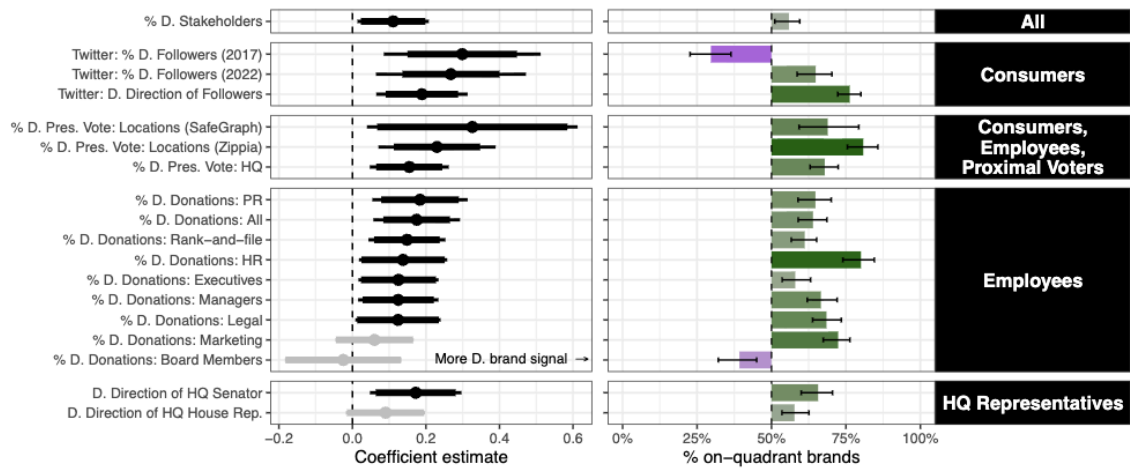
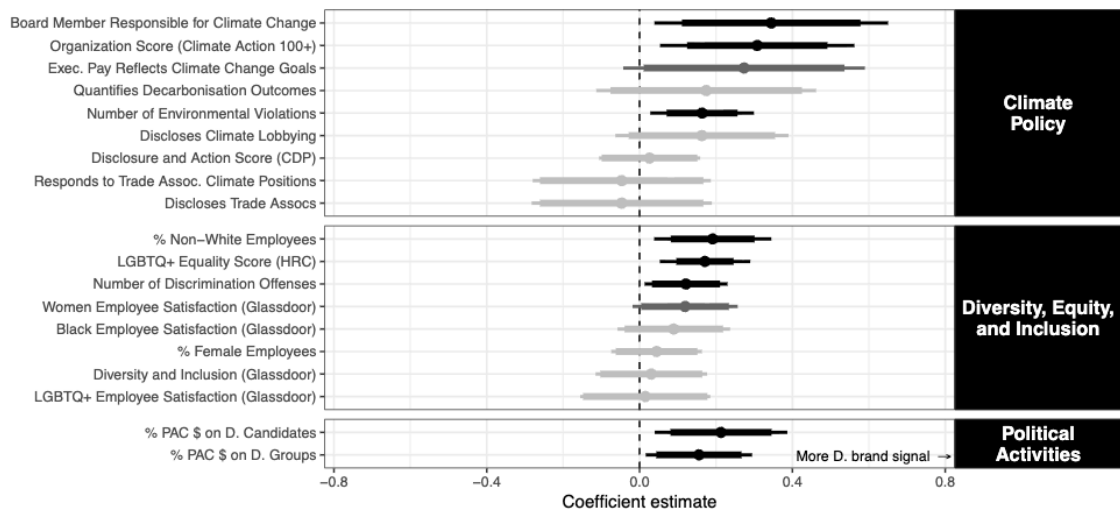


Figure 6. Alignment Between Brand Signals and Firm Political Activities



**Figure 7. Stakeholder Preferences Moderately Predict (*left*) and Align with (*right*) Partisan Brand Signals**



**Figure 8. Firm Agendas Weakly to Moderately Predict Partisan Brand Signals**



## **Response Letter**

This study provided the first comprehensive analysis of corporate political speech on social media, by computationally examining approximately 2 million posts from America's 1000 most popular brands between 2015-2021. The findings challenge the “woke capitalism” narrative. The results show that most brands are not meaningfully political. 64% of brands used any partisan signals, and 33% used more than 15 partisan phrases during the course of the study. Of the politically active brands, 73% of the partisan cues identified leaned left. This finding was more heavily concentrated in the aftermath of the George Floyd murder in May of 2020. The most common Democratic phrases included “climate change,” “gun violence” and “health care.”

Perhaps the most crucial finding of this study is that corporate political speech is moderately representative of stakeholders. Brand signals correlated positively with employee donations, consumer preferences measured through Twitter followers, and voters near retail locations. 57% of brands aligned with the net partisan direction of their stakeholders. The speech also had a weak to moderate correlation in predicting the firm agendas. However, the authors did indicate a potential paradox: brands with more regulatory violations actually signaled more progressively than other brands, which could be indicative of “woke-washing.”

This study contributes greatly to theory by testing stakeholder theory, and providing empirical grounding for corporate social responsibility discussions. It also contributes to the theory of the “diploma divide” in corporate America.

A major strength of the study is the multi-method validation, which included the Congressional reference corpus, the integration of computational measures, and many robustness checks. However, the study is not without its limitations. By using the Congressional language corpus, the researchers assume that this language accurately represents the political spectrum, which was likely missing some attributes, as well as potentially skewing the comparison. Platform limitations also raise questions about generalizability across platforms. No causal inference could be made about the study due to its descriptive and correlational focus.

This study ultimately raises some very important questions about this phenomenon, and provides a solid empirical foundation for further research. Further discussion and research should specifically examine the causal mechanisms of this phenomenon, and the temporal aspect of this phenomenon as well. From a methodological standpoint, how could multimodal analysis and sentiment analysis further be used to understand corporate political communication, and build off this literature? How does this study compare to Muddiman et al.’s (2019) use of manual dictionaries to run sentiment analyses on news story comments and political tweets, and what are the benefits versus limitations of these different methodologies?